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Dominance and defiance

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Document Type: Book

Original Page: 49

Culture (OWC): [Kanuri \(MS14\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1955-57, 1965-66

Coverage Date: 1955 - 1966

Place Coverage: Borno State, Nigeria

Section Title(S): Relations To Other Descent Groups

The terms for ego's own in-laws are senior (*k[unknown]sai*) and junior (*tiu*) affine. In general, all of ego's cognatic kin who are senior by birth priority are *k[unknown]sai* to his or her spouse, and all who are junior to ego are his or her *tiu* . In practice this may vary. Thus if a fifty year old man marries a fourteen year old girl, her eighteen year old brother is, properly speaking, this new husband's senior in-law. However, the status differences may be so great on other grounds that the terms get reversed and the older man becomes *k[unknown]sai* while the younger is *tiu* . Parents, aunts, and uncles of a couple refer to and address each other as senior-in-law.

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The data in Table 4:2 were gathered along with those in Table 4:1 above. It can be readily seen that the most stringent shame and respect relations are with spouse's own parents. When sexual differences are added (i.e., son-in-law to mother-in-law; daughter-in-law to father-in-law) the restrictions and avoidances become the most severe in the kinship system. These in-laws should never be alone together; only the most necessary conversation should pass between them. The junior in the relationship should avoid any direct confrontation with the senior. Thus if a daughter-in-law is on the way to the well for water and meets her father-in-law, she should pass quickly by with eyes downcast, or even move to one side so they will not have to pass side by side on a path. Indeed, communication is better handled between such persons through intermediaries related to one or both of the parties. Although less restrictive in practice, such relations are supposed to be extended to siblings of spouse's parents. Thus a wife's mother's younger brother might be on somewhat friendly terms to ego and could on occasion act as an intermediary between ego and his mother-in-law.

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TABLE 4:2. BEHAVIORAL NORMS TO AFFINES

<i>Kin type</i>	<i>Shame</i>		<i>Respect</i>		<i>Joking</i>		<i>Friendship</i>		<i>No Data</i>	
	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%
Wife father	47	98	49	100	0	0	0	0	0	0
Wi Mo	49	98	49	100	0	0	0	0	0	0
Wi Ol Sis	36	78	39	85	2	4	12	26	3	6
Wi Ol Bro	35	73	45	94	3	6	16	33	1	2
Mo Div Husband	16	42	35	92	1	3	1	3	11	22
Yo Bro Wi	16	40	26	65	5	13	7	18	9	18
Yo Sis Hu	14	36	27	69	5	13	16	41	10	20
Fa Bro Wi	15	33	43	93	0	0	0	0	3	6
Mo Bro Wi	14	33	26	60	6	14	7	16	6	12
Ego's Div Wi	11	30	23	62	16	43	1	2	12	24
Fa Sis Hu	10	23	40	91	2	5	5	11	5	10
Mo Sis Hu	10	22	43	95	2	4	6	3	4	8
Wi Yo Bro	3	6	5	11	40	87	13	28	3	6
Ol Bro Wi	1	2	29	64	41	91	8	18	4	8

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Ol Sis Hu	1	2	27	60	39	87	14	31	4	8
Wi Yo Sis	1	2	8	16	42	86	11	22	2	4

Given the importance of seniority to the Kanuri, it is not surprising that the next most restrictive affinal category is spouse's older siblings. These are given the same term (*k[unknown]sai*) as wife's parents. Although somewhat lower in shame-respect and higher in friendship than spouse's parents relative to ego, they are still classed for many purposes with spouse's parents, and many or most of the same avoidance can apply to them as well. Nevertheless, such restrictions are dependent upon age, sex, and status differences such that the greater the distinction socially between ego and his spouse's senior siblings, the stronger the restrictions, avoidances, and respect between the parties concerned. If this relationship is turned around and we view it from the senior's position looking  50 at a younger sibling's spouse, the shame responses are cut in half and the respect responses decrease significantly as well.²⁰ Thus 76% of those responding claimed a shame relationship to their older siblings' spouses while only 38% claimed a shame relationship to spouses of their younger siblings. Similarly, 89% felt respect with an older sibling's spouse while only 67% felt this way with a younger sibling's spouse. In other words, it is the junior who feels the greater restriction on his behavior. Indeed, in a minority of cases (13%) there are joking relations between the older sibling and his younger sibling's wife, while hardly anyone jokes with wife's older sibling. Similarly Ego (male speaking) feels quite friendly to his younger sister's husband (41%) and this is paralleled by a warm feeling close to his younger brother's wife. In the cases, where wife's older brother is head of the family and the spouse's father is dead, then wife's older brother is treated with the same shame and respect as wife's father.

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In one case, a young man has become so fond of his mother's co-wife (who is an important person in her own right) that he has become a client-son to her even after both she and his own mother were divorced by the common husband.

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